FRANMARINE UNDERWATER SERVICES PTY LTD

PERSON OVERBOARD EMERGENCY

Emergency Procedure

MV SEAGULL | UVI: 425689

Marine Order 504 (2024) — Schedule 1 Compliance

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Review Frequency

This document shall be reviewed at least every 12 months, or sooner following a significant incident, change of operations, vessel modification, or change in applicable legislation.

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1. PURPOSE

This procedure establishes the actions to be taken in the event of a person falling overboard from MV Seagull. It covers prevention, immediate response, recovery manoeuvres, and post-incident actions.

1.1 Regulatory Reference

Marine Order 504 (2024), Schedule 1, Clause 12. NSCV C7A (lifebuoy requirements). AMSA Safety Lessons — Practical Lessons from Person Overboard Incidents.

2. PREVENTION

Prevention of person overboard incidents is the single most effective safety measure. The following preventive controls shall be applied:

- All persons shall wear a lifejacket (SOLAS lifejackets are stored in deck storage midships; crew wear auto-inflate 150 PFDs) when the vessel is underway, during berthing and unberthing, and when crossing coastal bars (refer FUS-SMS-SGL-05E).
- Non-slip footwear shall be worn at all times on deck.
- Move around the vessel methodically. Maintain three points of contact when conditions are rough.
- Keep the deck clear of trip hazards including loose lines, tools, and equipment.
- Use the grab rails, hand holds, and bulwark rails when moving around the vessel.
- Exercise extra caution when conditions are rough or at night. Reduce speed, hold on, and communicate movements to other crew.
- Be alert when working near the gunwale, particularly during over-side equipment handling, mooring, and diving operations.
- Brief all crew on person overboard procedures before departure, including the location of the lifebuoy and the MOB button on the chart plotter.

3. IMMEDIATE ACTIONS — ALL CREW

On observing or suspecting that a person has gone overboard:

3.1 Raise the Alarm

- Shout “MAN OVERBOARD” loudly and repeatedly. State which side (port or starboard) if known.
- Point at the person in the water and do not stop pointing. Maintaining visual contact is the single most critical action. A person’s head in the water is extremely difficult to spot once lost from sight, even in calm conditions.

3.2 Deploy Flotation

- Deploy the lifebuoy with self-activating light and buoyant heaving line toward the person immediately.
- If available, also deploy a separate man overboard light or dan buoy (unattached to the vessel). An unattached floating marker will drift at a similar rate to a person in the water and provides a visible reference point even if the person is temporarily lost from sight. It also gives the person in the water something to swim toward.

3.3 Mark the Position

- Press the MOB button on the GNSS / chart plotter to mark the position electronically. Confirm the track recording is active.

3.4 Designate a Spotter

- If more than two crew are on board, immediately designate one person as the dedicated spotter. The spotter’s sole task is to maintain continuous visual contact with the person in the water (or the floating marker) and to point at them at all times. The spotter should position themselves at the highest vantage point available on the vessel (e.g. standing on the gunwale or hardtop if it can be done safely). The spotter does not assist with any other task.

3.5 Reduce Noise

- If safe to do so, shut down non-essential noisy equipment so that the crew can hear the person in the water calling for help.

4. MASTER'S ACTIONS

4.1 Confirm the Emergency

The most critical early step is confirming whether a person is actually overboard. If a crew member is reported missing but was not observed falling overboard, the master shall immediately conduct a rapid head count and check all spaces on the vessel (cabin, heads, foredeck) before commencing a search. Every second counts — this confirmation must be done urgently, not methodically.

4.2 Manoeuvre to Recover

The choice of recovery manoeuvre depends on whether the person is still in sight and the prevailing conditions:

Immediate Turn (Person in Sight)

For a small power-driven vessel like MV Seagull, the most effective manoeuvre when the person is still visible is an immediate turn:

- Reduce speed and disengage the propeller.
- Turn the vessel toward the side the person fell from, keeping the propeller away from the person.
- Approach from downwind or down-current so the vessel drifts toward the person, not over them.
- When alongside the person, shift the engine to NEUTRAL. Do not attempt to recover the person with the propeller engaged.

Williamson Turn (Delayed Discovery or Person Not in Sight)

If the person overboard was not immediately observed and the vessel has continued on its original course, the Williamson turn may be used to bring the vessel back along its original track to the point where the person entered the water:

- Put the helm hard over toward the side the person is believed to have fallen.
- After the vessel's heading has changed approximately 60 degrees from the original course, shift the helm hard over in the opposite direction.
- Continue the turn until the vessel has swung onto the reciprocal of the original course (approximately 180 degrees from the original heading).
- Steady the vessel on the reciprocal course. The vessel should now be tracking back along its original wake toward the point where the person entered the water.
- All crew should scan the water and listen for calls.

The Williamson turn is one of several recognised recovery manoeuvres. The master should use whichever manoeuvre best suits the conditions, the vessel's handling characteristics, and the situation. Regular practice during person overboard drills (FUS-SMS-SGL-04B) will build familiarity with the vessel's turning behaviour.

4.3 Communications

- Issue a PAN PAN call on VHF Ch 16 if the person cannot be recovered quickly, is injured, or is lost from sight. Advise the relevant port authority (refer FUS-SMS-SGL-05J for VHF channels) if in the operational area.
- If the person is unconscious or not found, upgrade to a MAYDAY on VHF Ch 16 immediately.

- Account for all other persons on board.

5. RECOVERY

5.1 Alongside Recovery

- Approach the person from downwind or down-current.
- Shift the engine to NEUTRAL when the person is alongside. The propeller must be stationary before the person is adjacent to the vessel.
- Recover the person via the diving ladder, boarding platform, or by using the buoyant heaving line and lifting over the gunwale.
- If the person is conscious and able to assist, direct them to the ladder or throw them the heaving line.

5.2 Unconscious or Injured Person

- If the person is unconscious or unable to assist, use a rescue sling, strop, or improvised loop under the arms.
- Call for assistance from all available crew.
- Avoid lifting a person vertically from the water in a harness if hypothermia is suspected — recover as close to horizontal as possible. Vertical extraction of a hypothermic casualty can cause cardiac arrest due to cold blood from the extremities returning to the core (circum-rescue collapse).

5.3 First Aid

- Once recovered, assess for injuries, hypothermia, or near-drowning.
- If the person is unresponsive and not breathing, commence CPR immediately and issue a MAYDAY on VHF Ch 16.
- Administer first aid using the Scale G medical kit (stored in the deck storage compartments aft). Administer oxygen if available.

6. PERSON IN THE WATER — GUIDANCE FOR THE CASUALTY

If a person finds themselves in the water, the following actions increase the chance of recovery. This guidance shall be covered during vessel induction (FUS-SMS-SGL-04A):

- Focus on controlling your breathing. Cold water shock causes involuntary gasping which subsides within 1–2 minutes.
- Do not attempt to swim after the vessel. Conserve energy.
- If a lifebuoy or floating marker is within reach, swim to it and hold on.
- Adopt the HELP (Heat Escape Lessening Position) to conserve body heat: draw the knees to the chest, cross the arms over the chest, and keep the head above water.
- If wearing a lifejacket, activate the whistle and light to aid detection.
- Make yourself as visible as possible by waving an arm when the vessel is in sight.

7. POST-INCIDENT

- Treat for shock and hypothermia. Remove wet clothing and wrap in a thermal blanket. Handle the casualty gently.
- Seek medical advice via VHF or phone. Proceed to the nearest port if medical evacuation is required.
- Do not give alcohol to a hypothermic person.
- Report the incident to the East Coast Operations Superintendent immediately.
- Complete an incident report and record all details in the vessel logbook, including: time the person went overboard (known or estimated), time of recovery, weather and sea conditions, actions taken, and condition of the person on recovery.
- Report to AMSA if the incident meets the threshold for a marine incident.
- Debrief the crew. Review the incident to identify any preventive measures or procedural improvements.

8. DRILL REQUIREMENTS

Person overboard drills shall be conducted monthly (refer FUS-SMS-SGL-04B). Drills should include:

- Deploying the lifebuoy and heaving line to a floating target (e.g. a fender tied to a small bucket as a drogue).
- Pressing the MOB button on the chart plotter and using the GNSS track to navigate back.
- Practising the immediate turn and, where practicable, the Williamson turn.
- Recovering the target using the diving ladder or by lifting over the gunwale.
- Practising at different times of day and in varying conditions where safe to do so.

Drill outcomes, including time to recover the target and any lessons learned, shall be recorded in FUS-SMS-SGL-04B.

9. REFERENCES

- FUS-SMS-SGL-06 Emergency Plan
- FUS-SMS-SGL-06C Medical Emergency Procedure
- FUS-SMS-SGL-05E Lifejacket Wear
- FUS-SMS-SGL-04B Emergency Drill Records
- NSCV C7A (lifebuoy requirements)
- AMSA Safety Lessons — Practical Lessons from Person Overboard Incidents
- Marine Order 504 (2024), Schedule 1, Clause 12